

SOCIAL NETWORKING

Digital LINK

Trudging long distances to revive links with old friends and attending parties to socialise is a thing of the past as networking acquires an all new meaning in a virtual world



■ By Chitra Subramanyam

Poke a friend, throw a sheep at a colleague, cyber-spy on that old high school crush or scan through pictures of that party where everyone was dead drunk. This is urban India's new-age answer to communication. Here it is just as easy to buy a cyber Mojito for that best buddy (it doesn't matter if you are underage) as it is to transform into a vampire or adopt an online pet. This is the place where a scrap doesn't necessarily mean an argument and social networking is no longer about wearing that slinky black dress to a poolside party. Instead the modern Indian netizen settles down to scour the Internet to meet buddies, make new friends or catch up

with those old, long-forgotten ones. Social networking is the new synonym for communication. Its share in the web space has grown as it brings with it the all-important fun element to interaction.

Not surprising then, that the Delhi-based online research consultancy JuxtConsult revealed that around 11 million urban Indians engage in social networking. These social networkers, the 2007 survey found, were more seasoned (63 per cent) than the average Internet user, clocking in at least two years online. Fifty-two per cent belonged to the group below the age of 25 and were largely male. They came from "technology" functional backgrounds, showed a higher owner-

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